

the irritant effect of the anthraquinones within the gut. The presence of oxalates suggests that yellow dock is best avoided in gout and kidney stones. The leaf has high levels of oxalates, and poisoning and death have resulted from eating the leaves as a salad vegetable.

Caution Avoid during pregnancy and while breastfeeding.

Ruscus aculeatus (Liliaceae) Butcher's Broom

Description Bushy evergreen perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has leaf-like leathery branches with a terminal spine, greenish-white flowers, and shiny red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Butcher's broom is found throughout much of Europe, western Asia, and North Africa. It is a protected species, growing wild in woodland and on uncultivated ground. Cultivated plants are gathered in autumn when in fruit.

Parts Used Aerial parts, rhizome.

Constituents Butcher's broom contains saponin glycosides, including ruscogenin and neoruscogenin. These constituents have a structure similar to that of diosgenin, found in wild yam (*Dioscorea villosa*, p. 91). They are anti-inflammatory and cause the contraction of blood vessels, especially veins.

History & Folklore Much used in antiquity, butcher's broom was described by the 1st century CE Greek physician Dioscorides as having the ability to promote urine flow and menstrual bleeding. The plant's name comes from its use as a broom in butchers' shops in Europe up until the 20th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though little used in Anglo-American herbal medicine, butcher's broom is now a common remedy in Germany for venous problems. It has been shown to have a directly positive effect on varicose veins and hemorrhoids, preventing increased tensing of the veins and helping the return of excess fluid into the veins. Extracts can be taken orally or applied to affected legs.

Research A growing body of research is demonstrating that butcher's broom is a valuable medicine for venous disorders. In a clinical trial, patients with varicose veins who applied a butcher's broom extract to their legs showed a contraction of 1.25 mm in their femoral artery within 2½ hours. A paper published in the *Journal of Complementary and Alternative Medicine* in 2000 identifies butcher's broom as having great potential as a medicine for orthostatic hypotension (a specific form of low blood pressure).

Caution Do not take butcher's broom if suffering from high blood pressure.

Ruta graveolens (Rutaceae)

Rue

Description Strongly aromatic evergreen perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has fleshy 3-lobed leaves, yellow-green 5-petaled flowers, and round seed capsules.



Rue powerfully induces menstruation.

Habitat & Cultivation Rue grows in the Mediterranean region, preferring open sunny sites. It is also cultivated in many parts of the world as both a garden ornamental and a medicinal plant. The aerial parts are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Rue contains about 0.5% volatile oil (including 50–90% 2-undecanone), flavonoids (including rutin), furanocoumarins (including bergapten), and about 1.4% furoquinoline alkaloids (including fagarine, arborinine, skimmianine, and others). Rutin has the effect of supporting and strengthening the inner lining of blood vessels and reducing blood pressure.

History & Folklore In ancient Greece and Egypt, rue was employed to stimulate menstrual bleeding, to induce abortion, and to strengthen the eyesight.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Rue is chiefly used to encourage the onset of menstruation. It stimulates the muscles of the uterus and promotes menstrual blood flow. In European herbal medicine, rue has also been taken to treat conditions as varied as hysteria, epilepsy, vertigo, colic, intestinal worms, poisoning, and eye problems. The latter use is well founded, as an infusion used as an eyewash brings quick relief to strained and tired eyes, and reputedly improves the eyesight. Rue has been used to treat many other conditions, including multiple sclerosis and Bell's palsy.

Research Rue is currently being investigated for its potential use as an anticancer treatment.

Related Species The related species, *R. chalepensis*, which is also native to the Mediterranean region, is used to expel worms, to promote menstrual flow, and to soothe sore eyes.

Cautions Rue is toxic in excess. Never take during pregnancy. The fresh plant frequently causes dermatitis, so wear gloves while handling it. Taken internally, rue may cause an allergic skin reaction to sunlight.

Salvia sclarea (Lamiaceae)

Clary Sage

Description Square-stemmed biennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has hairy wrinkled leaves and whorls of pale blue flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe and the Middle East, clary sage is now cultivated in France and Russia for its essential oil. It prefers sunny conditions and dry soil. It is gathered in summer, usually in its second year.

Parts Used Aerial parts, seeds, and the essential oil.

Constituents Clary sage contains 0.1% volatile oil (consisting mainly of linalyl acetate and linalool), diterpenes, and tannins.

History & Folklore Clary sage has been perceived both as a weaker version of its close relative, sage (*S. officinalis*, p. 131), and as a significant herb in its own right. Since the seeds were once commonly used to treat eye problems, clary sage was also known as "clear eye."

Medicinal Actions & Uses An antispasmodic and aromatic plant, clary sage is used today mainly to treat digestive problems such as gas and indigestion. It is also regarded as a tonic, calming herb that helps relieve period pain and premenstrual problems. Owing to its estrogen-stimulating action, it is most effective when levels of this hormone are low. The plant can therefore be a valuable remedy for complaints that are associated with menopause, particularly hot flashes.

Cautions Do not take clary sage essential oil internally. Do not use clary sage during pregnancy.